

33 Pharaoh of the Exodus

The king who asked, "Who is the LORD?" and learned the answer through ten plagues.

Exodus never names the Pharaoh who faced Moses. He ruled the greatest power of his day and was honored as divine. When Moses brought God's command to let Israel go, he refused, made the slaves' work harder, and hardened his heart through plague after plague. He bargained, confessed his sin, promised freedom, then took it back. Only after Egypt's firstborn died did he let the people leave, and then he chased them to the sea, where his army was lost. His story is a study in pride.

At a glance

Name	Not given. "Pharaoh" is a title meaning "great house"
Identity	Debated: Amenhotep II (early date) or Ramesses II (late)
When	c. 1446 BC (early date) or c. 1260 BC (late date)
Key places	Egypt, the land of Goshen, the Red Sea
Key people	Moses, Aaron, his magicians, his servants and officials
Main passages	Exodus 5–14
New Testament	Acts 7:18–36; Romans 9:17; Hebrews 11:27

"And Pharaoh said, Who is the LORD, that I should obey his voice to let Israel go? I know not the LORD, neither will I let Israel go."

Exodus 5:2, KJV

The life of Pharaoh of the Exodus

The text never names him, so any identification is a theory. On the early date, c. 1446 BC, many point to Amenhotep II, with Thutmose III as the earlier oppressor. On the late date, c. 1260 BC, most point to Ramesses II, with Seti I before him, though some suggest his son Merneptah. Other views exist. Exodus 2:23 says the king who sought Moses' life died, so the Pharaoh of the plagues was probably his successor.

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| c. 1446 BC
<i>Moses returns</i> | ● Refuses God
Moses and Aaron ask him to let Israel go to worship. He answers, "Who is the LORD?" and orders the slaves to gather their own straw while making the same number of bricks. <i>Exodus 5:1-21</i> |
| c. 1446 BC
<i>The first plagues</i> | ● Hardens his heart
His magicians copy the rod that becomes a serpent, the water turned to blood and the frogs. When the plagues ease, he hardens his heart and will not listen. <i>Exodus 7:8-8:15</i> |
| c. 1446 BC
<i>The later plagues</i> | ● Bargains and breaks his word
He offers to let Israel sacrifice in Egypt, then only the men, then all but the flocks. Twice he admits, "I have sinned," but each time he goes back on his promise. <i>Exodus 8:25-10:29</i> |
| c. 1446 BC
<i>Passover night</i> | ● Lets Israel go
At midnight every firstborn in Egypt dies, from Pharaoh's own son to the prisoner's. He calls for Moses by night and tells him to take the people and go. <i>Exodus 11:1-12:32</i> |
| c. 1446 BC
<i>At the sea</i> | ● Pursues and is overthrown
He regrets losing his slaves and chases Israel with six hundred chosen chariots. The sea parts for Israel and returns on the Egyptians. <i>Exodus 14:5-28; 15:4</i> |

Key activities

Exodus describes the hardening three ways. Pharaoh hardened his own heart (Exodus 8:15, 32), his heart was hardened (Exodus 7:14, 22), and the LORD hardened it (Exodus 9:12; 10:20; 14:8). Christians have long discussed how these fit together.

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- 1 Defied God.** He said he did not know the LORD and would not let Israel go. *Exodus 5:2*

 - 2 Increased the burden.** He called the Israelites idle and made them find their own straw for bricks. *Exodus 5:6-18*

 - 3 Relied on his magicians.** His wise men copied the first signs, but by the third plague they told him, "This is the finger of God." *Exodus 7:11-12, 22; 8:18-19*

 - 4 Bargained with God.** He offered partial obedience again and again, but never full release. *Exodus 8:25-28; 10:8-11, 24*

 - 5 Confessed without changing.** He said, "I have sinned," but when the plague stopped he sinned yet more. *Exodus 9:27-35; 10:16-20*

 - 6 Lost his firstborn.** The final plague struck his own house, and he sent Israel away. *Exodus 12:29-32*

 - 7 Chased Israel.** He and his servants asked, "Why have we done this?" and led the army after them. *Exodus 14:5-9*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names this Pharaoh.

Old Testament

Exodus 1–14	The main account, from oppression to the sea
Exodus 15:1–19	Moses' song over "Pharaoh's chariots and his host"
Nehemiah 9:10	Signs shown on Pharaoh and his servants
Psalms 105:26–38; 135:8–9	The plagues retold
Psalms 136:15	Pharaoh overthrown in the sea (whether he drowned is debated)

New Testament

Acts 7:18–36	Stephen retells the oppression and Exodus
Romans 9:17–18	"For this same purpose have I raised thee up"
Hebrews 11:27–29	Moses did not fear "the wrath of the king"
2 Timothy 3:8	Jannes and Jambres "withstood Moses"
Echo: Matthew 2:16	Herod also kills children to guard his power

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Pharaoh say when he confessed or bargained (Exodus 9:27–28; 10:16–17)?
2. *Understand:* What do you think it means that both Pharaoh and God hardened his heart?
3. *Apply:* Pharaoh offered partial obedience. Where are you tempted to obey God only halfway?
4. *Apply:* What promise did you make to God in a hard time that you need to keep?